CHATBOT PROJECT · ELEVENLABS VOICE

# Give your chatbot an expressive voice

Paste the prompt below into Claude Code inside your chatbot project. Claude adds two buttons, **Use expressive voice** and **Use regular voice**. In expressive mode your bot writes performance cues like `[warmly]` or `[laughs softly]` into its lines, and ElevenLabs' expressive model performs them. Your system prompt and your regular voice stay exactly as they are.

## How to use it

1. Open Claude Code in your chatbot project folder, with the app running.
2. Copy the prompt below and paste it in. Claude first finds your system prompt and voice code, then explains its plan before changing anything.
3. Approve the plan. Then try it: click **Use expressive voice**, chat for a few turns, and switch to **Use regular voice** to compare.

## The prompt

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My project is a chatbot with its own system prompt (I wrote it to give the bot its
personality and its job). Its replies are spoken with ElevenLabs text-to-speech. Add
an EXPRESSIVE VOICE option, so I can switch between my regular voice and an
expressive voice that performs the bot's lines with emotion.

Before changing anything, read the code and tell me:
(1) where my system prompt is defined and sent to the model,
(2) where the app calls ElevenLabs text-to-speech,
(3) where the chat interface is.
Then explain your plan and wait for my OK.

WHAT TO BUILD
1. Two buttons in the chat interface: "Use expressive voice" and "Use regular voice".
   - Only one is active at a time; make it obvious which one is selected.
   - I can switch at any point in a conversation. The choice applies from the bot's
     next reply.
   - Remember my choice when the page is reloaded (localStorage is fine).
   - Regular voice is the default.

2. Keep my system prompt exactly as it is. While expressive voice is selected, add
   this instruction to the END of my system prompt for each request (never edit or
   replace my own text):
   "An expressive voice performs your words. Add one or two short performance cues in
     square brackets right before the words they shape, e.g. [warmly], [gently],
     [excited], [curious], [laughs softly], [sighs], [whispers], [short pause].
     Match the moment and your personality; never more than two per reply; no other
     stage directions."
   While regular voice is selected, don't add it.

3. Cues are for the voice only.
   - Chat bubbles always show replies without the bracketed cues.
   - When sending the conversation history back to the model, remove the cues from
     earlier replies, so the bot doesn't keep copying them after I switch back to
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      regular voice.
   - The regular voice never receives cues: remove any bracketed cues from the text
      before sending it.

4. The expressive voice uses ElevenLabs' expressive model.
   - Send expressive replies with model_id "eleven_v4_turbo" (ElevenLabs' real-time
      expressive model).
   - If that request fails with any error except 401 or 402, retry once with model_id
      "eleven_v3".
   - These models only accept the stability and similarity_boost voice settings. Do
      not send style, speed or use_speaker_boost to them, and do not send
      optimize_streaming_latency (deprecated).
   - Apply my speed setting (if I have one) in the browser instead:
      audio.playbackRate = speed, with audio.preservesPitch = true.
   - The regular voice keeps its current model and settings, unchanged.

5. A test button. Next to the two voice buttons (or beside any existing voice test
   button), add "Test expressive voice". It speaks, through the expressive model:
   "[warmly] Hi there, this is my expressive voice. [laughs softly] I can sound
      pretty excited... [whispers] or keep things quiet. [curious] So, how does this
      sound to you?"

RULES
- Don't change my system prompt, my bot's behaviour, or how the regular voice sounds.
- Never put the ElevenLabs API key in a URL. Send it in the request body or a header.
- When you're done, run the project's type check and linter, fix anything they
   report, then tell me exactly how to try both voices.
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## Good to know

- **Your system prompt isn't changed.** While expressive voice is on, one short instruction is added after it. Switch back and it's gone.
- **If your system prompt forbids special characters or brackets,** the bot may refuse to add cues. Loosen that rule or add an exception for voice cues.
- **You need your own ElevenLabs API key** already set up. The expressive model uses your ElevenLabs credits like the regular voice.
- **The voice you pick matters most.** Some voices perform cues far better than others. Try a few.
- **Expressive replies start a little later** than the regular voice. If your account falls back to `eleven_v3`, the delay is longer.
- **Style and speaker boost don't apply** to the expressive voice. Stability, similarity and speed do.
- **Cues aren't followed perfectly.** ElevenLabs says tag-following is still improving, so expect the odd cue to be ignored.